

Economic Analysis Memo

ECON 2010 – Macroeconomics

Spring 2019

Due Date

Due at the start of class **XXX, 2019**.

You have **two weeks** to complete this writing assignment.

Assignment Overview

This assignment asks you to write clearly and cogently about current issues in the macroeconomy. Unlike your problem sets and exams, being able to understand news about the macroeconomy, and communicate your understanding to others (whether written or orally) is a real-world skill that I hope you have begun developing as a result of this class.

There are two articles attached to this assignment. To complete this assignment, you'll **choose one** of these articles to summarize and analyze (i.e. connect to our class content). You only need to choose one! You will have 3-4 pages to complete this summary and analysis.

First, you'll summarize the article (i.e. you'll answer the question *What does this article say?*). In the process, you'll link the article's content to our course content by answering questions like the following. *What macroeconomic topics are being discussed in the article?* Explain the topics in your own words. There may be many topics at play in the article, but in a short amount of space, you can't necessarily discuss all of them. Be selective. What is absolutely necessary for someone to know to understand the point of the article? Avoid focusing on concepts that we haven't learned in class. In being selective, you can get into more explanatory *depth* about each topic and really show how much you know. Prioritize those topics that seem most important in the article (e.g. those that you discussed most in your article summary).

You'll also explain: *How is the concept used and applied to the real-world situation in the article?* In this way, you'll also analyze the points made in the article. That is, you won't just tell your reader the main point of the article and then list definitions of concepts. You need to re-make the point of the article and tell your reader what those concepts mean *in the context of the article*.

You will also answer whether *There are links to additional concepts that the article doesn't consider*. If the article tells you that one concept is related to another, your summary should explain *why*, which may require that you draw on additional concepts from class beyond those explicitly discussed by the article.

You should think of your reader as a smart colleague from the college program who's interested in the macroeconomy, but who doesn't know much about it. And remember: this assignment does not ask for your opinion on the article, nor your own thoughts or feelings. It simply asks you to

re-state and add explanatory depth to what the article already says.

Assignment Details

You must understand the article in order to complete these assignment, and you must be able to discuss it in your own words with appropriate explanations of economic material that you've learned in class.

Additional guidelines:

- The page limit is 5 pages. There is no minimum, but a good summary will likely be more than 2 pages. But a longer assignment isn't necessarily better! Use your pages wisely.
- If at all possible, please type your memo, but it is not required. If you hand-write, please be kind to your reader (me!) with your handwriting.
- Handwritten you may write single spaced. If you type your summary, it must be double spaced (with 1 inch margins and 12 pt. font).
- Refrain from using quotations from the article, the textbook, or other class materials. A good memo is unlikely to use *any* quotations. The purpose of the assignment is to put the article's content into your own words, and quotations directly interfere with that!
- Please indicate somehow which article you are summarizing. It is likely to be obvious, but to be completely thorough, please either mention the article in the text (i.e. "The main point of so-and-sos article entitled something-or-other is..."), or you can list it at the top of your assignment.
- You do not need to provide a works cited or any citations for this assignment.
- You do not need a title or heading, but if you want one, go for it.
- Make sure that your name is on the summary.
- This assignment is all about summary (explaining in your own words the main points of the article). This is not a writing assignment in which you are making an argument. Therefore, you do not need, and in fact *should not have*, a thesis statement.
- Furthermore, this is *not* an opinion. Therefore, your summary should not include your opinions about whether the author of the article is "correct" or not, or whether you agree or disagree with the point of the article.
- Focus on concepts that we've studied in class. If the article mentions things that you don't understand, feel free to ask questions during class before the assignment is due, but in general try to avoid making those important parts of your summary. How can you explain them if we haven't learned them?! Those do not make sense to focus on.
- The articles also discuss many concepts. You cannot describe and explain all of them. So, first, focus on the main point of the article. Then think about the most important sub-points and choose some (but not all) from among those.

Assessment

This writing assignment counts 10% towards your final grade.

Your summary will be assessed on the following:

- The accuracy with which you capture the main points of the article.
- Your explanation and appropriate use of relevant economic concepts.
- Your ability to connect your explanation of the relevant concepts to the point(s) that the article makes. This is critical: If the article mentions GDP, and you define what GDP is, that is helpful. But to get full marks you need to connect your definition to the point in the

article and, likely, explain more fully *what it is about GDP* that matters.

- The clarity and correct use of writing conventions (grammar, spelling, etc.),
- Your adherence to the above guidelines.
- Improvements you have made relative to the last writing assignment (i.e. your ability to incorporate the feedback your received to make this assignment better).